

Chapter I - The Mistakes

*This setup
doesn't come back
in the story*

The mistakes didn't show up right away. Their endemic nature only became apparent when it was far too late. That's the thing isn't it, about mistakes: they're always presumed to be incidents. And yet when they're not - then what?

A mis-take: implies that one can try again, do a retake, that one can recover from it, like a misstep. It implies that it can be fixed, the mis-take. How untrue that assumption proved to be.

What is the mistake?

Until last year we still thought all was swell - how blithely unaware we were. And weak, too weak to perceive the signals. And had we, then we were used up to stop them. That's how wrung-out we had become.

what are the signals?

Before we divulge more salient facts and gory details of the enfolding cataclysm, consider the exponential - or logarithmic effects (I'm a writer, not a mathematician) when mistakes start interacting.

Clusterfuck does not begin to describe it. This clusterfuck was of the sneaky kind. It crept up on you with a long incubation time, like that of a virus. However unfair this might seem to us humans, let's not forget viruses are not encumbered with any sense of morality.

Alright, so what about the clusterfuck, you ask? It was the machines. They were powerful, the machines.

The machines.

colossal implosion somewhere unseen in the industrial sector of the Westelijk Havengebied. The lights flared then collapsed, the train shot forward in a final paroxysm, then flew off its rusty undercarriage and plunged off the embankment into the watery ditch just after the Vinkebrug in the no-mans land of Spaarnwouderveen.

~ * ~

When she came to, it was to screaming agony in her head, blurred vision and a 100 dB high-pitched whine in her ears. Her limbs were tangled in those of other passengers. she could hear moaning, some cries, distorted and far off, as if she was in a fishbowl.

She knew then she had to get out, get out, get the heck out of that cadaver of a train. Pulling herself up out of the soft and warm bodies, covered in a shimmering lake of shards of glass, the leaking battery fuel dripping down wildly, and fizzling wiring dangling dangerously, she pushed into someone's sickly soft stomach, who groaned and then nothing. Extricating her legs, sore and scraped and her canvas pants torn, but her boots thankfully both still on, though covered in red grimy entrails, she retched but clawed her way upwards to the rent in the chassis, to the ashen wintry light.

Chapter II - To The Copse

The air outside was cold and remarkably still - if you'd ignore the mediaeval loss of life in the crumpled remains of the train mangled like an accordion on the rutted embankment.

Dora stood bent over, clasping her knees and gasping rasping breaths that burned her lungs with the cold. The wretchedness of the accident and the warm blood on her boots overturned the contents of her already stressed stomach, and a small puddle of yellowish bile lay steaming in the grass. "Yellow, 'cause of the PCM," she thought uselessly.

~ * ~

The Anthropocene Department of the Ministry of Cultural & Natural Affairs had not skimmed in its self-congratulation on the effectivity of the Cooling Programme: thusly formed in order to counteract the more negative aspects of the aforementioned age, such as the wild-fires on the western Seaboard, mass extinctions in Southern Aztecia, the cataclysmic flooding of most of the coastal zones of Eurasia wiping out several million Bengali, Myanmari, Thai, Hindi and Tamil.

Yet in all their patting of backs, the department had quite overlooked that the populations of Canadian geese had long been decimated by said blistering wildfires, so no down-insulated parkas for Dora or other shivery Europeans.

~ * ~

So that's why she was so darn freezing, though the cold served to calm her neurotic heart beating a fool rhythm in her throat. She looked around expectantly - no, more than expectantly - needing the security of certainty seeing or hearing any sign of life: that of a fellow commuter; a co-worker; any human noise - even a simple "Hello." Or a even just a cry for help. But no, none of that, just a chiffchaff bleating in a copse on the other side of the nitrogenous-green field.

The lead-coloured clouds were perched low like dark predators and met the fog rising from the peat. Dora knew it wasn't peat, just sludgy clay, but it was an age-old saying and being traditionalist, that alone gave her comfort.

Nary a human sound was to be heard and she felt exposed and alone. Although now a slight hissing growing in amplitude, emanated from the crumpled remains of the SubT. Also steam. Steam that quickly blackened into oily smoke, which burst into flames in a space of thirty seconds. "Like the quiz game," she thought irrelevantly.

probably a meme? I don't know

From the recesses of her mind, original, human, unpredictable, fragile, weak and emotionally unstable she fumbled for the visapass in her parka pocket and flung the battered emblem of servitude into the gaping maw; now belching happy flames about shoulder-height quite unabashedly.

She would always say that that moment was not a moment of temporary insanity, quite the opposite: a coming to.

~ * ~

short). The bubbly HR ensign, Ms. Dolores Lasterar, evidently had no idea what the job entailed and could barely read out the tasks: “improving infallibility of records... de-mystifying historical events... objectifying sentimental causes...”

Dora’s wild enthusiasm at this one-in-a-million opportunity was abruptly doused by the condition that she stop her vlogging instantly. Doable, her followers had been lured away to the next fad (AI-generated spaghetti-eating frogs). The interview continued amicably, the ladies sipping their tepid teas from seaweed cups.

On the subject of Ms. Olivetti’s fit for the role, Ms. Lasterar curiously labelled Dora’s childlike exuberant vlogging as “manifest... uh, conscientiousness and diligence for recording historical documents,” reading from the prepped dossier.

Some instinct refrained Dora from correcting Ms. Lasterar’s misconception— not only because the likeable brunette shuffled in her seat and was rather red in the face, what with all the fancy words she had to read, and any affront might cause her to break down in tears— but because being presumed meticulous seemed a key requisite for getting this bonanza of a job. Though it was hard to tell what the job really entailed because of Ms. Lasterar’s botched rendition.

Fiddlesticks, thought Dora, *consider the perks of ample grog and B2-grade lunch thrown in, a no-brainer, yo!*“ and Dora Olivetti signed her bureaucratic DocuCommit then and there.

Yet her elbow fracture had throbbed all throughout the interview.



The copse was slightly elevated due to its erstwhile purpose as an Iron Age fortification. Built on the upturned hulls of expended riverine craft; discarded animal bones, shards of pottery, and other flotsam and jetsam, it was essentially a raft, or, for the optimistic, a house on poles. Yet sheltering an information-age

trove. ← *not a sentence*

When Dora was about done in with plodding through the sludge, she stubbed her toe on one of these bones— and set off the silent alarm. The copse was overgrown with brambles, hawthorns, and stunted willows. A small opening looked like a path to something dry to her, and she crouched down and crawled in. Then strong, hard hands pulled her down, and she tumbled down slippery plastic into a dimly lit cove. Of sorts.



“Who the hell are you and how did you survive THAT,” barked a gruff but young voice attached to a skinny young man with a scraggy beard and blonde wispy hair covering what looked like bright blue eyes. On saying “that,” he waved his gangly arm in a broad arc like a crooked windmill. After sliding down, Dora was sat on her butt in a plastic dome that was rather a nasty, dirty, wet hole, filled with the ends of worms and an oozy smell.

“Look, dude, I just got here and got lucky, so give me a break!” she snapped. “And for that matter, what the heck are YOU doing here?!”

Only then did she notice three humanoid creatures crouching a few metres back, in the gloom of what looked like a corridor. Scared these might be partisans or rebels or incels; or the unvaccinated; the unpassed - in any case probably hungry and violent - she made an appeasing gesture with her hands.

“Look, it was a mess, I don’t know what happened. I knocked my head. But the lights went wild in the SubT and then we got like a power surge and then the whole thing shot out of the Halfwegtunnel and derailed and everyone was dead or dying except me,” she explained hurriedly. “So I know as much as you do, okay. Oh yeah, my visa pass I tossed into the fire, so I’m nobody now. By the way, my name’s Dora, and you...?” she extended her right hand.

Chapter IV - The Houtrakkers

The Houtrakkers were, in fact, partisans. As well as anti-clerical, anti-establishment, anti- well, anti-everything really. And luckily for them, and lucky for Dora, definitely anti-AI, anti-capitalist and autarchic. These beliefs, in combination with a healthy dose of paranoia, had them vest their privacy and humanity in their own hands. Their foresight had them cache their biometrics a decade before the right-wing preppers realised their “freedom” was being encroached on.

The core of the group was led by Tako: named such not after the maize snack from Mexico, but after the Japanese word for octopus. His tentacles were everywhere: reaching through the Inter-web, the Dark Market, the Crypto Singularity and far, far beyond.

The group consisted of about five to ten members at any given time. They only had ten names to give out: the Dutch names for the numbers one to ten. When someone left (which was only to start another Houtrakkers group somewhere), they would vacate their name and choose another Japanese fish or mollusc as a name. Why? Because of Douglas Adams’ book *So Long, and Thanks For All the Fish*, naturally.

~ * ~

“Come, let me show you our place,” Tako said. The trio denizens scattered away

into a dark passageway. “Never mind them, introductions will come later.” He crouched and moved into the passageway and a dim light flicked on.

“We’re re-using the derelict fortifications from the defenses created in the Napoleonic era and 20th century. They weren’t considered viable defences in this day and age of cyber warfare - all the more useful for our purposes. These tunnels connect to the Liebrug Fort which is only a stone’s throw away on the other side of the A4 underpass. Not that anyone comes there anymore.” He ran his hand over the mossy glistening brickwork.

“We use the dampest chambers to grow mushrooms, we make all sorts of stuff from them, clothes, food, *insulation* material, bedding...” He took a righthand corner. “Some parts are always wet, those we cover in seaweed mats, to dry them out, like where I grabbed you and you tumbled down.”

Dora was adamant to keep her keen sense of direction in the dark underground, but her head was still befuddled from the crash so she gave up pronto. “Great brickwork though,” she said, “But how did you know I was coming? And how come the emergency services weren’t all over the crash site in a flash?”

“Ah yes, good question, but one thing at a time. We do have an elaborate silent alarm system strung up around the perimeter of our den. I’ll show you the Control Room first,” and he slung his lanky frame around another corner.

“We also registered the crash on our seismograph. Not that impressive, in this bog.” He stopped in his tracks and swung around to face Dora and looked at her piercingly. “Although we must still establish whether we can fully trust you. Can we?”

Dora expelled a breath she didn’t realise she was holding. “Yes, yes of course,” she blurted, surprised by her sudden need to want to be trusted by this rakish blond

Spaarnwouderveen. We have props of normal objects or entities like rabbits and fishing herons - but they are just props. You'll find quite a lifelike farmer scarecrow behind the row of willows perched on his tractor - a dummy on rails. We have drones disguised as chiffchaffs. We have green screens which portray nothing going on whilst we work behind them. And we have green suits- “

Dora interrupted Tako, “So you're really the little green men!” she exulted. Tako laughed.

“Yes, in fact we are, But we need an emissary to move between our world and the outside one and we just can't get a visapass because we don't exist. So you have to go and get your replacement.”

“Okay... but won't they think I'm dead?” questioned Dora.

“They might, but we're not sure,” Tako pondered, playing nimbly with a guitar pick, flipping it across his knuckles.

“The thing is, we made sure you made it out. You had an 84% fit on the profile of becoming a proper emissary. I know I said I was surprised at you when you first came down here, but that was a bit of a fib, to see if you were bona fide.”

Dora puffed with pride, but felt instantly let down, and said indignantly, “What d'-you mean, only a 84% fit? What 16% doesn't fit, 'ey? What am I lacking? Not up to proper Houtrakkers' standards? And you lied to me as well?!”

“The fit? Well that's largely a matter of definitions and calibrating our weighing system.”

Dora scoffed at this woolly talk. Tako resumed, and becoming more precise, said, “What the percentage means is that there's 16% that is simply unknowable about you. And that's rather curious. I consider that in itself to be a good thing, so on

Chapter V - The Party/The Hangover

The Damiate clocks struck half past nine in the evening. The clocks would ring about twenty minutes to allow people in hearing range to hurry to the city walls and enter the gates before they were bolted shut for the night. It's never too late to modernise a mediaeval practice they must have thought.

The scent of chicory coffee wafted through the dark room that was Dora Olivetti's chambers in Schoten^a, municipality in the Hollands. She sat hunched over old-fashioned playing cards on a table, a pale LED candle flickering reflections in the two coffee mugs on the table. Opposite her sat a cross-legged figure, languishing and blowing smoke rings. Slender and red-haired, all legs, she gazed at the cards on the table, bored.

"What does it mean, Dora? Those dratted Tarot cards?"

"Let's see, the High Priestess... and the Tower, reversed... Not good I think..."

"Oh it's all rot, isn't it? Magic doesn't exist," and Molly puffed another smoke ring.

Dora stretched her back and said, "Sure, Molly, and that joint will also cease to exist for me, so don't Bogart that joint," and she held out her outstretched hand, her index and middle finger apart so Molly could slide the delectable unit between them.

"Ahh, that's better," as Dora pulled the smoke deeply into her lungs and said with a constricted voice holding in the smoke as long as possible, "Look, we'll get into the right Tarot frequency puffing this thing. It's def from her travels in Morocco,

my aunt, no doubt about it you see. I read her journal from her travels in the 1980s. *Du vrai skif*, it said.” She exhaled the last of the acrid smoke, downed the dregs of chicory coffee and grimaced at the bitter taste. “Too bad I ran out of saccharine last week, sorry about that,” and she looked apologetically at Molly.

“Wesh...” drawled Molly. “All the more reason to break out that Avezé booze, it’s a far out party waiting to happen and I think we ought to get properly imbibed before the others arrive, since I know all about their insatiable appetites for anything fermented.”

Dora reached into the drinks cabinet on the left hand side of the comfy chair she was embedded in, conveniently placed within arm’s length, and stretched out to pull two thrift-store shot glasses which — peering at the glasses in the light of the LED candle — were just about clean enough to warrant consumption out of. Another reach of an arm procured a dusty bottle with a yellowing label, curling at the edges. “Yes, the bottle was under the kitchen sink, between the chlorine and the cleaning vinegar, classic.”

“Good job your French studies finally amounted to something useful, knowing what Avezé is,” said Molly admiringly, whilst Dora uncorked the bottle with her teeth and sloppily poured the amber liquor into the shot glasses. “Here ya go, bottoms up, or *santé, à la tienne*, as I should say!”

They both grimaced at the bitter gentian taste but smiled bravely at the windfall the demise of Dora’s aunt had proffered. The doorbell chimed, just as the last of the Damiate curfew bells ebbed away.

“Trust Erwin and them to be just in time,” Dora said as she clambered out of the creaky wooden fauteuil, mangy with years of cat attention.

Dora peered through the video camera to see if it were indeed Erwin and co. “When’s Bloomsday? Also the year!” she challenged, although asking this pre-arranged password was more of a literature buff gag than necessary spy craft, since she could easily identify Erwin from the way his eyes goggled the camera, and his two cronies joking in the background as well.

It had started off as a joke, these passwords, but since China had taken over large swathes of Africa for cheap labour and raw materials, drones were so cheap that every municipality used them for monitoring dog owners for poop scooping (a good thing), to masquerading as your friendly neighbourhood watch (not a good thing).

Their humming and buzzing had become part and parcel of the urban auditory landscape. One could spot them hovering like dragonflies in front of windows, and if they were flummoxed by sheer curtains or reflective window film, then unscheduled follow-up visits by all too nosy so-called electricians, meter boys, milkmaids were a dead cert - all standard data-collection safety protocol. So yes, one needed to baffle the bots. And since the machines were still largely insensitive to concepts of time, temporality and the depth of meaning of poetry; dates and obscure literary or poetic quotes were a staple. This time it was James Joyce providing the inspiration.

“Of course, *ma biche*, that’s 16th June 1904. A Thursday,” he said.

“Who’s that with you then, ‘Leopold’?” she asked, although she was quite certain Erwin’s companions were Gaelle, the sax player, and Puck, who worked in the hardware store selling bathrooms. They’d all met playing the AR-game underground ripped-off version of Pokémon, Insectomon, where you had to

evolve insects and viruses.

“All right, come on in, but I hope you know it’s BYOB.”

“No worries,” said Erwin through the tinny microphone, and a cardboard bag containing what looked like a bottle was held up to the camera. Dora unlocked the door, slid back the bolt and undid the latch. All strictly analog. Government certified electronic front door locks were child’s play to hack, and this fact was not popular with the authorities. Any mention of its ubiquity was greeted with proverbial gritted teeth, and brushed off as tripe and retrowiped by an army of top notch bots scouring the socials.

They tumbled in, and Dora said, “Next time expect a password from *The Hobbit*,” and they hung their damp cold jackets on the wooden pegs acting as a makeshift coat rack. Stomping their feet, their glasses condensed with the fickle warmth supplied by the bio-methane installation in the buildings.

Dora waved them to the grotty kitchen with a grandiose flourish and announced, “Glasses and booze in there for equitable redistribution. Let the festivities begin!”

The party progressed as a tropical storm might - from one gentle breeze to a firm blustery buffeting wind, music thumping louder and arms and legs gyrating, to kisses on blushing cheeks, to a fiercer whirlwind and finally to a palm-tree bending hurricane force, when arms and legs intertwined and glistening lips ~~kissed~~ were pressed on smooth lips and sweaty embraces exchanged in small cramped nooks and crannies of couches and loveseats.

↑
were

~ * ~

The curfew nudged parties into all-nighters and sleepovers - everyone had to

spend the night regardless. Or not go to sleep at all, and clamber into a duffel parka at six o'clock in the morning, stealing a liquorice root from the pot on the shelf near the door to lamely conceal the sickly-sweet cannoning hangover breath that could curdle milk and make babies cry.

“Catch you later, Dora, faya party,” whispered Erwin in Dora’s ear, who mumbled something vaguely affirmative and snuggled closer into Molly’s arms.

Molly, although quite the party animal, as well as more into experimental knowledge than the stuff from books, woke up when Erwin and co dragged their shabby selves out of the apartment.

“Yo Dora, you gotta get up, you don’t want another Neg Point at work...” she smoothed a blonde curl from Dora’s cheek and gently shook her. “Okay, I’m going to make us some chicory coffee...” and she extricated her gangly body from the couch and Dora’s embrace.

~ * ~

Dora exited the Houtrakkers' den on the north side, the side furthest from the trainwreck that she'd rather not see. Clambering out through the twisted willow branches and the fake bramble door, she appraised the concealment of the den. There were some serious camouflage experts out there in the group, she thought. Worrying that she might rip the shiny synthetic suit, despite Tako's assurances, she crawled out on hands and knees, waiting for the signal, a triple chiffchaff call.

Rather clumsily she got to her feet. The hood of the green suit also completely covered her head with gauze for the eyes and a slit of the mouth. She heard the chiffchaff call thrice, and saw the drone flap ungainly to the west, indicating the direction she needed to follow.

The sky was dove grey and the wind blew chill in from the Polar north. Would it swing a bit more to the west, then snow was to be expected. She looked furtively to the south, towards the embankment. The wreckage and human remains had gone. The power lines were again twinkling in the wind, all repaired and stretched taut. She felt the slight tug of wind indicating a SubT - was it the 16:19 to Rijnsoever? - approaching through the tunnel. She ducked, still unsure about the adequacy of her camouflage. The train whizzed by unconcerned.

She swallowed hard, glad the wreckage and the human tragedy had been obliterated. How? How had they cleaned it up? And so quickly? How had they been able to take care of the bodies? Had they even taken proper care of the deceased? What about the next of kin? She turned to look behind her, and just barely discerned the green screen that had been posited to hide her exit - she was part of the landscape now. On a rails in front of her, hidden near the ditch, a projector hummed while pixelating the pastoral scene.

positioned

Chapter VIII - Dora's Gear

So hoarding ran in the family, kind of. Not something you'd readily admit to, because it was a virtue to chuck things out, preferably after a single use. Such was the drive for welfare, that to buy, expend, dispose, were touted on the socials as being really modern traits, like tranga, swa. ?

Except Dora was a typical cognitariat sisa, and chucking out stuff like broken cables, or plugs used in the British Commonwealth, or assorted rolls of duct-tape, old screws, perfboards, LEDs, half-used notebooks was not something she had a heart to.

And now she would be vindicated, because this junk, stored in plastic containers neatly Dyno-labeled "junk" would mastermind her into the Houtrakkers.

She just hoped her previous girlfriend had not carried out the threat of clearing out "those damn antique boxes of crap" because the one thing she could promise the HRs, was two eighties telephone sets, rotary phones - which when properly connected to a switchbox, would facilitate untraceable and unsniffable communication.

She wolfed down the still-hot boboti, and her eyes smarted at the Mme Jeannette sour chili heat. She visualised her basement storage of 9m2, going through the contents in her mind's eye. Soured pages of Harry Potter adult edition books, photos, camping gear, an old tent, early 20th-century hand tools, GI Joe dolls, curtains from the previous tenant, too ugly to put up, but who knows, maybe to someone's taste...

She'd have to lean over the spare bicycle parts, but presumed balancing on an old wooden snow sled in the rear left, would be the Dyno-labeled curver boxes. Being a ghost, she was glad she hadn't yet run into one of the nosy neighbours and decided to time her visit to the basement at eight o'clock in the evening sharp, when the obligatory news was broadcasted in a blaring tooting fashion from the TV-set. She turned on her set, sat the cardboard effigy of herself in front of it, and putting her hoody over her head, snuck out the door and down the hallway to the far end of the fire escape stairwell.

~ * ~

The cheap LEDs in the bare concrete basement flicked on with the motion sensor as she approached.

They'd been installed the year before — much cheaper and more efficient, but of course the returns weren't redistributed to the tenants, as she had vainly hoped, so there was no lower rent.

Turning the corner to get to her storeroom, she heard the sound of wood crushing. She took a peek around the corner, still conscious of her deceased state, a total wild card when meeting people. She saw Raymond, her elderly next-door neighbour, attempting to force entry into her storage space with a makeshift crowbar. No time for niceties.

“Ah-hem,” she said loudly, and strode toward the culprit. “What’s the meaning of all this then?” She hoped her forceful and loud tone would dampen the boomer’s mulish tendency to contradict anyone’s opinion, as well as distract him from the glaringly obvious fact that she was very much alive.

her painkillers with him to tackle his gout. She had a niggling feeling that underneath Raymond's feeble and contrarian boomer demeanour lay a nugget of resolve as hard as a walnut, something not even the authorities had yet managed to crack. Indeed, it was hidden, in hibernation maybe, and cherished — like a squirrel hides its cairn and sleeps curled in its furry red tail, counting the little hazelnuts stashed safely away. And squirrels could bite when cornered — perhaps they even carried rabies?

~ * ~

She'd check in with him later, the fridge still had some days' juice left. She opened the door, and switched on the light. She noted that the frame had suffered from the crowbar, she'd grab some wood filler to camouflage the damage.

Now where were those boxes? Right where she visualised them; luckily the ex-gf had not carried through her threats of declutterisation.

Dora scraped the excess filler from the crushed frame and it looked as new. Newish, at least. The only giveaway was the smell of solvent. She hoped it would dissipate soon enough to not lead any one to her storeroom. As an afterthought, she smeared filler on edges of three other doors, so there would be no direct lead to her storeroom.

She lugged the plastic containers and the makeshift crowbar up the concrete bare stairwell three flights up, noticing how her body still throbbed with the remnants of the ordeal of the crash. The blood in her head thudded ominously loud. Before she arrived at her landing, she stopped to catch her panting breath, and listened before she pushed open the fire door a crack and peered into the empty hallway.

Not a soul in sight, because ^{the} news broadcast hadn't yet run ^{its} course. The weather report had recently been extended to twenty minutes because they didn't want to broadcast much real news. Besides, the public networks had been decimated by a few decades of right-wing yobs, preferring the drivel of commercialised influencer gossip thinly veiled as information.

"Tomorrow's weather... is statistically likely... to be exactly the same as today..." she muttered. *Though who was interested in statistics and fact anymore* she wondered cynically as she heard the weather reporter's voice in multi-stereo through all the frontdoors she passed in the corridor making it back safe and sound with the prized telephones back to hers.

Chapter IX - The Fjord

What happened to the funeral?

It's nigh impossible to go about one's actual business when you've been left out in the cold. Dora was still fuming inside at the folly; yes the folly; the Houtrakkers and that wispy imp Tako, in particular, had left her in.

(not a sentence)
The expectant evening, hustling into the Cold War bomb shelter under the Fjord community centre. She had been mortified - she'd brought all her friends; vague acquaintances; groupies; roadies and a rando busker or two. Even Mr. Ate had slipped away unseen when he'd had half a chance. The worst was Molly's look of derision and worst of all, pity.

The stage had hummed with 50Hz, a single breath was enough to tilt it into banshee-style eardrum-shattering feedback whines. Primed like a grenade, the sound engineer had rustled up all the vacuum tubes, condenser mikes, and guitar pedals Jimi Hendrix would have been proud of — he'd had to pilfer the juice from the daycare centre just to fuel the 1960s pedal by EHX *Electric Lady* a vintage beaut.

~ *** ~

? don't understand the transition

Too bad the little moppets from the daycare centre would have tepid chestnut milk tomorrow. No doubt enough cause for the authorities to launch an investigation; uncover hacking; blame it on spies in the PTA; close the centre for weeks; have the urchins wander the streets nicking and begging straight out of Dickens.

Benevolent side-mission accomplished.

It was an unspoken truth that daycare centres were merely disguised brainwashing facilities. Some suggested there was something added to the children's milk. In the stifling straitjacket of the daycare centre, which served as a breeding ground for zombie-like citizens, the children's minds were hobbled from day one.

What better than to have them fend for themselves: mucking about in the streets, playing mock trench warfare, getting scabby knees, falling out of trees, burning cats' tails, stealing lunch from the old fogeys' walker-mounted shopping bags — and in future, new recruits for the partisaners.

The risks she'd taken, holing up in the broom closet of the daycare centre with Molly... They had prodded Molly's niece to help out - she worked in the daycare centre and was deliciously and unabashedly naive. So when Molly said she needed to practise her broom-sweeping for the local contest, she had said, "Brilliant, good luck it's all yours," and invited us to stay after hours, when the closing song celebrating the Exalted Leader had had its rout, and *en passant* providing us with the code of the alarm box as well. The code was what we had already surmised, namely the birthday of our Exalted Leader, Dustin, 22_11_63.

We stole some of the protein bars (*only 55 % insect, 45% lab grown goodness*) that were reserved for the young tykes. God, they were tasty, if a bit crunchy. Chinese South-West Africa had experienced a particularly fecund locust bumper crop last spring.

The stolen kisses in the closet combined with the cloying taste of the sticky protein bar and the whiff of lemony smell from the detergents stored there were to be committed to memory forever. Giggling and whispering, and fondling each other together, waiting for the curfew and the dark. *Infinitely preferable to playing*

Chapter X - Phil

She recalled her first day at the department, not so long ago.

“Welcome, Ms. Olivetti, esteemed comrade, to our humble department!” said Mr. Phil Cortana, her new Supervisor — or as he was officially designated, Shift Leader level 1.01. He waved her into the hallway of the 11th Floor. The lights were rather dim, since the solar power hadn’t the force at seven o’clock in the morning to power them properly. It was still dark outside and it was a glum sight. The Westelijk Havengebied was populated with morose and rickety ships, dilapidated cranes, forking crummy metal waste into big bins meant for resmelting, in the forges that were belching brown clouds of lignite exhaust. In the gloom behind the exhaust pipes loomed a squat black building blotting out half of the northern horizon.

Mr. Cortana wiggled his eyebrows as he gestured for her to pass her coat to hang on the sparse and dripping coatrack in the corner of the hallway. “Pass me your coat please, ms.,” he said, and she quickly though clumsily took off her coat and grotty scarf.

“What a nice view,” she crooned, passing him her weathered parka, “I always wondered how far one could see from this impressive building! Is that the New Economic Data Box - I mean Data Archive?”

“Oh yes, well this isn’t the half of it, just wait until you see old Schoten when it gets lighter!” He puffed with pride, as if he had personally designed the view himself. He held up her bundled coat and scarf as if it was a wet cat, far away from

him, and hung it on an unoccupied hook on the coat rack.

Mr. Phil Cortana was dressed that day - and every day as she would learn - in khaki slacks, ironed to perfection, and a white dress shirt that was old and a bit tatty around the wrists, but again, fastidiously creased. He shook his left hand ostentatiously so that a gleaming wristwatch emerged from under his sleeve.

Obviously she couldn't give a rat's arse about her supervisor's outdated taste in fashion accessories, but understood that it would flatter her new boss's ego, and therefore was an invitation she couldn't nor shouldn't refuse. Better yet, it would probably go quite a way towards getting her first Pos Point.

“Wow,” exclaimed Dora with Oscar-material faked surprise, “Is that a 20th century Seiko or Casio? I’m impressed — it’s quite the ordeal to keep them old LCDs going!”

“Thank you, that’s quite right, it’s a nineteen nineties Seiko, and I found some old batteries in my late father’s inheritance so I got it to work again, like clockwork, hi hi hi,” he tittered, chuffed at his little double-entendre.

Phil shook his left wrist once again in that irritating manner befitting hirsute middle-aged men of Mediterranean descent. Dora decided to compliment him on his restoration skills but thought he was a doofus because he didn't know how to adjust the metal clasps of his wristwatch to fit his wrist better.

✗ “I suppose taking good care of old materials is a merit for this job, isn't it?”

“Absolutely,” blustered Phil, his unibrow wiggling like a fat black caterpillar, “and your powers of observation and knowledge of antiques is duly noted! Follow me, I'll show you your work counter, or charrel as we call it, and introduce you to your two closest scribe comrades.”

He shuffled forward out of the antechamber followed by Dora, the latest addition to the legion of cognitarian drudges and entered the work floor - a giant expanse of low small desks and monk-like scribes poring over low-lit computer screens and tapping away at high speeds. It sounded like the trillions of wings of a vast cloud of locusts — a constant droning that was rather calming in a rather numbing fashion.

Her guide's shuffling gait sped up as he nimbly slalomed from left to right through the labyrinthine office. Somewhere left of the middle of the complex Phil ended his ballet through the office space with a little flourish of the hips.

☒ "Well pay attention comrades Erwin and Tricia, here she is, your new comrade, Ms. Dora Olivetti."

The two drudges looked up, both bespectacled, simultaneously. Out of habit as not to appear like intelligentsia, they also took off their glasses simultaneously. Their shining smiles, dilated pupils and blushing cheeks showed that they had had ample experience with Voigt-Kampff tests.

The man, a bit pudgy and squint in his left eye, was a stooping hulk of a man, but had a friendly face and a weak, wet handshake. To compensate for that emasculating trait, he pumped her hand up and down like a piston.

☒ "Erwin, Erwin Adler is the name, nice to meet you, comrade Dora," he said, his voice soft, and a bit monotonous. Despite the squint in his eye, he made quite the effort to pin her gaze down, and his handshake was becoming sweaty and uncomfortable.

The other drudge, rather more handsome with spiky blond hair and a pixie smile, relieved Dora of Erwin's eagle's clutch.

"Come on, Erwin, give her a bit of a rest from that fierce grip! Hi, I'm Tricia —

Tricia Hermes. I do retro-wiping, especially of left-wing tree huggers and niche feminists of the nineteen-eighties,” and she shook Dora’s hand, nudging away Erwin, who grimaced clumsily and grasped for his glasses.

“Oh, and Erwin here is the expert in the Auditing Laws and Bylaws, especially the section on wikipedia driven disinformation tactics,” continued Tricia.

Dora smiled and bobbed her head like a proper little newbie bumpkin though Mr. Cortana’s demeanour never left the scrutiny of her beady eye. She was not under any impression that the flying colours she’d sailed in on were a guarantee for any lasting leeward refuge.

~ *** ~

Dear old unibrow Phil; a little person in the cogwheels of the gruelling bureaucracy; was all the more formidable as adversary - being shackled by his insignificance and knowing it. He had futile KPIs, OKRs, OGSMs to report, puerile assessments to complete, and his only leverage was the utter fickleness of the judgments he meted out on us.

Phil Cortana, who must once have aspired to greatness like the naive rest of us; yearned of enlistment as a Blade Runner perhaps - before his brows met each other above the bridge of his Roman nose. Yet when his Pokémon skills faltered at level forty-nine, when his Fortnite skills were staying delulu, round about that time he must have realised the limitations to his character and career advancement were as stark as the unibrow harshly delineating his visage.

A bonus of his bristly bricky was he needed no Voigt-Kampff test — he was the master of the monobrow, and it indicated his moods as accurately as a barometer

Chapter XI - Zoning for Success

On her way to work, she was still fuming. She felt the Houtrakkers had let her down by not coming to the Fjord and she had no way of contacting the Houtrakkers or get the telephone sets to them. She'd have to enlist Erwin's help to get back to the bicycle; for which she could think of no logical explanation unless she involved him in this web of espionage. And he was too sweet to be involved in that.

Neither did she look forward to hoisting herself into that godawful green suit-stocking again. Speaking of which — where had she left that darn thing? The blood drained from her face when she realised she might have lost it, fallen out of her pocket. She had no idea in the slightest when last she had felt that creepy, slick stocking in her parka pocket.

The train rocketed out of the Halfweg tunnel, and she involuntarily braced herself for the impact. The abrasions and bruises were only just fading. She took a deep breath, and surreptitiously scanned her fellow commuters' countenances — were they really all that amnesiac?

How entirely effective the combination of propaganda, emotional dampening, structural attention-draining, retro-wiping, and mild malnutrition were to keep the man down. Where was the stocking?!

Barely a week ago, the train had been filled with thousands of other people — these gits were their replacements. They were as sweet as they come, as meek as lambs. Casually scrolling the news bulletins and regurgitated torpid drivel, as if

rades might make concerning the tendentious reasons for her absence.

? not sure this works here

Underlying her resolve to be irreproachable, was her fervent hope that the Houtrakkers could be relied on to have informed her workplace and chef Phil that her absence was indeed credible and justified. Were they to be trusted? After the no-show at the Fjord, she was deeply unsure.

To add to her need to prepare for faultlessness, was the weasely nature of her chef, Phil Cortana. A conniving, wormtongue mouthbreather of a creature - and not easily duped.

→ boss,
not cook

~***~
→ I thought she only started a few months ago?

He had been on her case since last year at the XDay party – hunching too close to her, his vile breath from a long-neglected halitosis curdling the very air. His eyes bloodshot from the nitrogen dioxide emissions near his poorly ventilated flat in the Baarsjes estate.

His voice hoarse from the fracking chemicals leaching into the water supply, he rasped, “My department is short on NegPoints, Ms. Olivetti, so just beware, I might need to push you out of the Zone of Success and into Reticulating Splines!”

Dora shuddered at the memory, and the blustery wind grew in strength and blew wetly from the West through her parka.

Reticulating Splines was a re-integration, or demotion, where one was assigned to the twenty-second floor, the Testing Floor. It was one step removed from being sent-off permanently - the fate of many too overt intelligentia - to the open-pit lithium mines in Chinese Congo. It was dangerous to appear a know-it-all, ~~and~~ ^{so} Dora, Erwin and Tricia dumbed down their speech and it was common to remove

one's glasses when in public - at least, when there was no danger of stumbling around like a fool or stupidly misidentifying people and ~~hence~~ drawing unwanted attention to oneself.

Dora walked hurriedly along the verge of the crumbling pavement, the EVs speeding and rickety fat-bikes trundling by.

She hoped that Tricia or Erwin would also have their shifts and help deflect Phil's stinging barbs. He would feel he had been cheated out of dealing her a bunch of NegPoints. Phil was such a NegPoint master, that it was hard to imagine the department of A, D C & F without him and his unibrow.

~ *** ~

She decided it would be wise to time her arrival with that of the next SubT, when carriage loads of co-workers would thrum into the lobby of the imposing mottled blue 23-storey Tower. The gates would be swamped with bleeps and blips scanning the visacards and any discrepancies would evade the gaze of the eagle-eyed security ladies perched behind their buttresses.

Dora meshed into the other wet and cold and damp co-workers, who were all still groggy with what she presumed to be the wearing off of *Painoquel* and who took no notice of her joining their ranks from another direction.

The noise in the lobby from the stamping of feet on the grotty and soggy mat in the lobby of the D-Tower masked the thudding of her heart beating in her throat.

The female security guards, or Hawk-Eyes, were selected for their meticulous eye for detail; a neurodiverse trait turned to sniffing out any change in the workforce's demeanour that was a pervasive manifestation of subterfuge or

subversion: a snazzy hairdo, a strange bruise, or worst of all - an all too confident gaze. Sure warrants for an investigation and a long stint in Reticulating Splines on the Testing Floor.

The throng patently hid Dora from the brunt of the hypervigilance of the Hawk-Eyes and she arrived on the Eleventh Floor without a hitch. Still her mouth was dry, and although there was still an hour to go until the morning chicory break at half past ten o'clock, she was yearning for a cup of the bitter brew - the best they could in their rank and Fief was 90% water. Where the other 10% was sourced from, they chose not to find out.

She beckoned to fellow cognitariat chica, Tricia, whose eyes were habitually bloodshot on Monday mornings, indicating a voluntary pollution of the lungs with *skif* or the like. They had warmed to each other within a few weeks of Dora's start as Retro-Wiper.

~ *** ~